

OTT GAVE VIEWERS EARTHY FARE IN *PANCHAYAT*, SPECTACLE IN *HEERAMANDI*, AND GRITTINESS IN *THE FAMILY MAN* OR *SACRED GAMES*



Begums of Binge
Sept. 13, 2021

"Three women have been at the forefront of the streaming revolution, leading the creative wings of three of the most popular platforms: Aparna Purohit, head of India originals at Amazon Prime Video; Monika Shergill, vice-president, content, at Netflix; and Ekta Kapoor, joint managing director, Balaji Telefilms. Brought together for the first time for an INDIA TODAY cover shoot."

All was not lost for Bollywood either. Mainstream hits may have been few and far between, but a wave of small-budget gems kept the flame burning: *Death in the Gunj*, *Lipstick Under My Burkha*, *Aligarh* (2016); *Village Rockstars*, *Newton* (2017); *Tumbbad*, *Badhaai Ho* (2018); *Laapataa Ladies* (2023), to name just a few. Payal Kapadia's luminous tale of three Malayali nurses navigating life in Mumbai, *All We Imagine as Light* (2024), bagged a Grand Prix at Cannes, the first Indian film to do so in 30 years. Bollywood discovered the virtues of franchises too, with YRF setting up a spy universe with Tiger, Pathan, and Hrithik Roshan in spy thriller *War*, and Maddock a horror comedy one with *Stree* and *Bhool Bhulaiyaa*.

This decade had its share of divisive cinema, too, particularly films seeking to "set the historical record straight", from Vivek Agnihotri's *Tashkent* (2019), *Kashmir* (2022) and *Bengal Files* (2025) to Sudipto Sen's *The Kerala Story* (2023). Serving patriotic fervour on the side was Vicky Kaushal-starrer *Uri: The Surgical Strike* (2019).

What of *Animal*, Sandeep Reddy Vanga's 2023 film featuring Ranbeer Kapoor, which left audiences wondering how much is too much graphic violence? Love it or hate it, the box-office approved. ■